

Pikachu Plush Visits the Space Station

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A Pikachu **plush** has been to space! The European Space Agency, or ESA, shared the news on September 19, 2026. The toy spent 67 days on the International Space Station, or ISS.

Pikachu went there on a Cygnus **cargo** spacecraft on April 11. It returned to Earth on a SpaceX Dragon **cargo** spacecraft on June 17. While in **orbit**, it traveled around Earth about 1,040 times.

The trip was part of ESA's plans to celebrate World Space Week 2026, which runs from October 4 to 10. ESA made a special **exhibit** that mixes space science with Pokémon characters. It shows Europe's space missions and life on the ISS. Visitors can learn how ESA studies the Sun, the Solar System, and the wider universe.

The **exhibit** tour began at ESA **headquarters** in Paris, France, in late September. It will visit places across Europe through April 2027.

Pokémon GO players can join activities at **participating** science and space museums in Europe. These run from October 4, 2026, through April 30, 2027. They include One-Star Raids with Astronaut Pikachu, research tasks, and chances to encounter event-themed Pokémon.

ESA hopes the project will make children and teens curious about space and science. ESA Director General Josef Aschbacher said, "Inspiring future generations is a key part of ESA's mission."

Word Treasure

plush -- A soft stuffed toy.

cargo -- Goods or supplies carried by a vehicle.

orbit -- A path around an object in space.

exhibit -- A display that people can visit and explore.

headquarters -- The main offices of an organization.

participating -- Taking part in an activity.

Break it down

Introduces the Pikachu plush's visit to the ISS.
Explains its spacecraft journeys and trips around Earth.
Describes World Space Week and ESA's traveling exhibit.
Gives the locations and dates for Pokémon GO activities.
Ends with ESA's goal and Josef Aschbacher's statement.

Why it matters

The exhibit connects a familiar character with information about space missions and life on the ISS. ESA hopes this will encourage children and teens to explore science.

Test what you remember

1. How long did the Pikachu plush spend on the ISS?
 - (A) 40 days
 - (B) 104 days
 - (C) 67 days
 - (D) 17 days
2. Which spacecraft brought Pikachu back to Earth?
 - (A) A space science research spacecraft
 - (B) A space station crew capsule
 - (C) A Cygnus cargo spacecraft
 - (D) A SpaceX Dragon cargo spacecraft
3. What does ESA's special exhibit mix together?
 - (A) Weather science and Pokémon characters
 - (B) Ocean science and Pokémon characters
 - (C) Plant science and Pokémon characters
 - (D) Space science and Pokémon characters
4. Where did the exhibit tour begin?
 - (A) At ESA headquarters in Paris
 - (B) At a game exhibit in Madrid
 - (C) At a space museum in Berlin
 - (D) At a science museum in Rome
5. Where can players join the Pokémon GO museum activities?
 - (A) At participating museums in Europe
 - (B) At participating museums in Australia
 - (C) At participating museums in Asia
 - (D) At participating museums in Africa
6. What does ESA hope the project will make children curious about?
 - (A) Sports and fitness
 - (B) Food and cooking
 - (C) Space and science
 - (D) Music and dance

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: D 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Josef Aschbacher: He said inspiring future generations is a key part of ESA's mission.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):